

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MEXICO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action decides project outcomes in Mexico. The clearest proof is a river in Guerrero. When the Federal Electricity Commission (CFE) moved to build the **La Parota** dam on the **Río Papagayo** near Acapulco — a 900-megawatt project that would have flooded some 17,000 hectares, displaced 25,000 people, and harmed 75,000 more downstream — the affected campesinos did not wait to be consulted. In 2003 they formed the **Consejo de Ejidos y Comunidades Opositoras a la Presa La Parota (CECOP)**, blocked the CFE's engineers from their communal land, and fought on every front for more than two decades. Their decisive weapon was distinctly Mexican: because the land was collectively owned, the project needed the consent of the community **assembly (asamblea)** — and when the CFE tried to manufacture that consent through rigged assemblies, CECOP took the matter to the **agrarian courts**, which **annulled the fraudulent assemblies**. Alongside that, an **amparo** — Mexico's constitutional injunction — froze the illegally granted environmental clearance and water concession. In 2012 the state government signed accords promising not to build the dam without the communities' consent, and in July 2026, after twenty-three years of resistance, the federal government **cancelled La Parota definitively**. A state-owned mega-dam was beaten in the end because a community owned its land in common, guarded the assembly that spoke for it, and used the courts built for exactly that. The story is worth grasping in full. The CFE had eyed the Papagayo since the 1970s; when it relaunched La Parota and sent engineers onto communal land, campesinos from three villages blocked them on 28 July 2003, the very day that CECOP was born. The agrarian court in Acapulco — Tribunal Unitario Agrario no. 41 — nullified the assemblies the CFE relied on, and in 2007 a federal judge granted an amparo suspending the environmental clearance and water concession. In 2012 the Cacahuatpec Accords with the state government promised no dam without the communities' consent, and in July 2026 the federal government declared the project cancelled for good. The cost was heavy — CECOP endured internal splits, repression, and the imprisonment of leaders such as Marco Antonio Suástegui — but the river still runs, and the communities still hold their land.

La Parota teaches two things about winning in Mexico. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the collective land and its assembly, the agrarian courts, the amparo, prior consultation, the environmental authorities, mobilisation, and national and international attention — pressed for as long as it takes. The second is distinctly Mexican and worth stating at the outset. Roughly half of all the land in Mexico is **social property** — **ejidos** and **comunidades** owned and governed collectively — and a project on that land needs the **asamblea's** consent, enforceable through specialised **agrarian courts**. Layered over that is the **amparo**, a fast and powerful constitutional suit that can **suspend** an act that violates rights. Together, collective land and the amparo give Mexican communities two of the strongest tools any people anywhere hold against an unwanted project.

Most communities, though, do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They attend one meeting and go home. They assume the project "is already decided," and so they never guard the assembly, never take a rigged approval to the agrarian court, never file an amparo, never demand consultation, never file a denuncia with the environmental authority, never build the mobilisation that changes a decision. They generate a burst of outrage without a plan to sustain it. They gather a crowd and lose it to exhaustion. The gap between a community that stops a project and one that watches it get built is rarely courage or numbers. It is method.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Mexican system.

The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the decision and its weak point)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build proof of harm and of every defect)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(organise a movement that lasts)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES	(the assembly, the agrarian court, the amparo, consulta)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make the fight visible and impossible to ignore)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the legal case and the media story at once; the movement sustains the pressure that decision-makers and courts respond to; a lawsuit is a headline and a headline strengthens a lawsuit. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. CECOP did exactly this — it documented the harm, organised a durable movement, guarded and defended its assemblies in the agrarian courts, fought with amparos, and made La Parota a national and international cause, all at once, for twenty-three years.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Mexico's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Collective land and the assembly (asamblea).** On ejido and comunidad land — roughly half the country — a project needs the assembly's consent under the Agrarian Law. Guard the assembly, and you hold a gate the project must pass; if it is manipulated, you can have it annulled.
- **The agrarian courts.** Specialised **Tribunales Agrarios** decide disputes over social property and assembly decisions — the forum that nullified the rigged La Parota assemblies.
- **The amparo.** Mexico's constitutional protection suit can win a **suspensión** freezing an act — an environmental permit, a water concession, works — that violates rights such as the right to a healthy environment, to water, or to consultation.
- **Prior consultation.** Under **ILO Convention 169** and the Constitution, Indigenous and equivalent communities have a right to free, prior, and informed **consulta**, and the Supreme Court has struck down projects and permits granted without it.
- **Environmental authorisation and the citizen complaint.** Projects need an environmental authorisation from **SEMARNAT** based on an impact statement (**MIA**), and any citizen can file a **denuncia popular** with the enforcement agency **PROFEPA**.
- **A deep resistance tradition.** From the countryside to the cities, Mexico has a powerful tradition of community and campesino mobilisation.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always prevail. Assemblies can be **manipulated, bought, or split** by a determined proponent, as the CFE tried at La Parota — vigilance is constant. The federal government pushes large infrastructure hard and has **declared major projects matters of "national security"** to shield them from injunctions and scrutiny — a tactic used around the Tren Maya and other megaprojects, and only partly curbed by the courts. The amparo is powerful but can be **slow**, and suspensions can be contested. And Mexico is one of the most dangerous countries on Earth to defend land and the environment — CECOP's own leaders faced imprisonment and persecution. This guide takes those facts seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to win anyway — and, where an outright stop is not realistic, how to secure the delay, the conditions, the exposure, and the worn-down proponent that, in a hard fight, are often what winning actually looks like.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

The Levels of Decision

A Mexican development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The land and its assembly. If the project sits on **ejido or comunidad** land, the decisive gate is the **asamblea** — the collective assembly that, under the Agrarian Law, must consent to the use or transfer of the land. No valid assembly, no valid project. This is often the strongest and most distinctly Mexican point of leverage.

Environmental authorisation. A project with significant impact needs an **autorización de impacto ambiental** from **SEMARNAT**, based on a **Manifestación de Impacto Ambiental (MIA)**, and often a **water concession** from **CONAGUA**. These federal permits are frequent targets of challenge.

Consultation. Where Indigenous or equivalent communities are affected, a **consulta previa** under ILO Convention 169 and the Constitution is required — and the courts have voided projects that skipped it.

The courts. Two forums matter above all: the **Tribunales Agrarios** for disputes over collective land and assemblies, and

the federal courts through the **amparo**, up to the **Suprema Corte de Justicia de la Nación (SCJN)**, for violations of constitutional rights.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a proposal, to attempts to secure the **land** (an assembly vote, a purchase, an easement), to the **MIA and environmental authorisation** and any **water concession**, through any **consulta**, into the **courts** if challenged — agrarian and amparo — and only then to construction. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The earliest doors are the cheapest and widest: guarding the assembly, a denuncia to PROFEPA, evidence that the MIA is deficient. The later doors — annulling a rigged assembly in the agrarian court, an amparo against the permit, a consulta claim — are more demanding but real, and communities walk through them and win, as CECOP did. Find out exactly where your project stands on this path today; that tells you which door is open now.

Follow the Money and the Permit

Behind the project stand a proponent (sometimes the State itself, as with the CFE), its financiers, its contractors, and the officials who authorised it. Trace who owns and funds the proponent, who profits, and which authority granted the land use, the environmental authorisation, and the water. Two questions unlock most Mexican fights: **Was it lawful — the assembly, the MIA, the water concession, the consulta — and were the impacts honestly assessed?** and **Who benefits from pretending they were?** Where the State is the proponent, the political and reputational fronts matter as much as the legal ones. And even a State proponent has exposures a community can reach: contractors and suppliers with reputations to protect, development banks with environmental and social standards, and a government that must answer to voters and to international scrutiny. Mapping who builds, funds, and profits from the project reveals pressure points that the permitting file alone never shows.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **Tribunales Agrarios** and the federal courts up to the **SCJN** review legality and rights. **PROFEPA** enforces environmental law and takes citizen complaints. The **Comisión Nacional de los Derechos Humanos (CNDH)** examines rights violations, including against defenders. The **Auditoría Superior de la Federación** audits public money, and, since Mexico ratified it, the **Escazú Agreement** protects environmental information, participation, justice, and — vitally here — defenders. Each overseer is a separate front, reachable with the same evidence, and a project rarely survives pressure on several at once. You do not have to choose one door: the same well-documented file can go to the Tribunal Agrario, the federal courts through an amparo, PROFEPA, the CNDH, the auditor, the proponent's financiers, and the press at once, and each front that opens makes the others harder to close. A Mexican campaign's power comes not from any single lever but from applying several at the same time — with the guarded assembly as the foundation the whole structure rests on.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Mexican and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the project sits on **ejido or comunidad land** (which puts the assembly in your hands), whether **Indigenous consultation** is engaged, whether the **environmental authorisation or water concession has real defects**, whether an **amparo** can win a suspension, whether the government has shielded the project as "national security," and whether the public and the proponent can be reached. Where collective land and consulta are engaged and the community organises, Mexico's levers are strong; where the paperwork is clean and the State is determined, discount the figures and think in terms of delay, conditions, exposure, and mobilisation.

Individual Step Success Rates

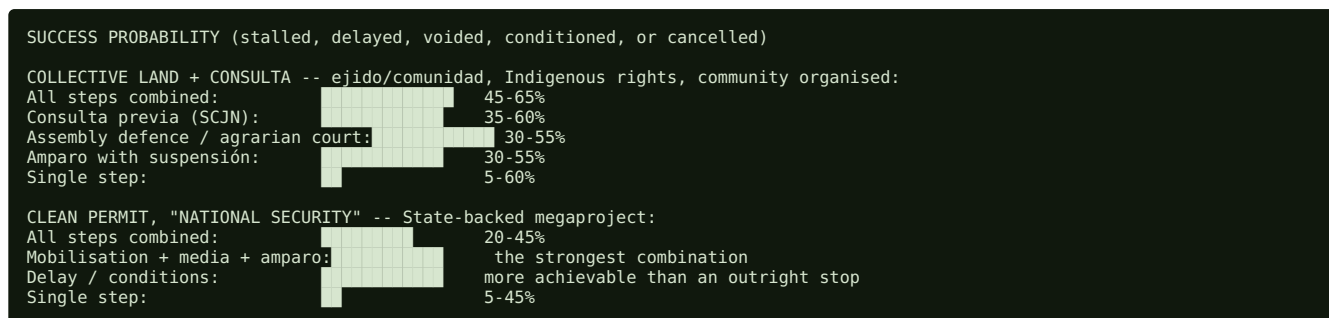
Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	1-3 months	low	Basis for every other step
Guarding / defending the assembly	30-55%	ongoing	low	No valid land consent; project stalls
Annulling a rigged assembly (agrarian court)	30-55%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Fraudulent approval voided (the CECOP lever)
Amparo with suspensión	30-55%	months-years	low-moderate	Permit/works frozen for rights violation

Consulta previa claim (ILO 169, SCJN)	35-60%	1-4 years	low-moderate	Permit/project voided for no consultation
Challenge to the MIA / environmental authorisation	25-45%	1-3 years	low-moderate	Authorisation suspended or annulled
PROFEPA denuncia popular	20-45%	months-years	low	Inspection, sanction, or suspension
Water-concession challenge (CONAGUA)	20-45%	1-3 years	low-moderate	Concession questioned; project constrained
Transparency / information route	high for disclosure	weeks-months	low	Documents released; defects exposed
Media & public campaign	30-55%	ongoing	low	Political cost raised; decision shifts
International / financier pressure	25-50%	6-48 months	low	Backers or buyers walk away
All steps combined (collective land, consulta)	45-65%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Stalled, voided, conditioned, or cancelled
All steps combined (clean permit, "national security")	20-45%	1-5 years	low-moderate	Delayed, exposed, conditioned; sometimes stopped

Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Mexico's real strengths are distinctive — **collective land and the assembly**, the **agrarian courts** that void rigged approvals, the **amparo** with its suspensión, **consulta previa** that the Supreme Court enforces, the **MIA and PROFEPA** environmental route, and a **deep resistance tradition**. Its constraints are **assemblies that can be manipulated**, the government's "**national security**" shielding of **megaprojects**, the **slowness** of the amparo, and **grave danger to defenders**.

A note on cost: guarding the assembly, filing a denuncia to PROFEPA, and requesting information are inexpensive, and human-rights and environmental organisations (such as the network that supported CECOP), agrarian-rights lawyers, and legal clinics carry amparos and agrarian cases. The amparo does not require a lawyer in theory, though one helps greatly. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is committed legal support — for the agrarian court, the amparo, and the consulta claim — and the reach of the media and mobilisation, exactly what CECOP marshalled over two decades.

Effectiveness Visualization



How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Mexico are **collective land, the agrarian courts, consulta, and the amparo** where they apply, and **the mobilisation and the media** everywhere. La Parota shows the ceiling: a community that owned its land in common, guarded its assemblies, and fought in the agrarian courts and with amparos beat a state mega-dam over twenty-three years. The floor is set by manipulated assemblies and by a government that shields its megaprojects as "national security." Most Mexican fights sit between them, and the honest lesson is that collective land, the courts, consulta, and mobilisation are real and distinctive levers — but against a determined, State-backed project, the realistic win is often delay, conditions, exposure, and a proponent worn down, as much as an outright, permanent stop. Use the table to plan, not to predict: it tells you which combinations have historically done the most work and where to put scarce time first. The single most important reading is that no row on its own is as strong as the rows run together — the community that guards its assembly, documents everything, files its amparo, presses consulta, and publicises at once consistently outperforms the one that pins its hopes on any single move.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Collective land and the assembly, defended in the agrarian courts** — Mexico's most distinctive lever; the gate that, guarded, a project cannot pass, and, if rigged, can be voided — the CECOP lever.

2. **The amparo with its suspensión** — the fast constitutional injunction that freezes an unlawful permit or works.
3. **Consulta previa** — the ILO 169 right the Supreme Court enforces by voiding projects that skip it.
4. **The mobilised, sustained movement** — the CECOP tradition that holds the line and makes a project a national cause.
5. **The environmental route and media** — the MIA challenge, the PROFEPA denuncia, and the coverage that raises the cost of proceeding.

What Mexican Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Collective land can stop a mega-dam** — La Parota proved it, through assemblies that the community guarded, defended, and, where they were faked, had annulled. **The agrarian courts void rigged approvals** — the fraudulent assemblies the CFE relied on at La Parota were annulled by the Tribunal Unitario Agrario, pulling the legal ground out from under the dam. **The amparo freezes projects** — a suspensión halted the dam's illegally granted environmental clearance and water concession while the case was fought. **Consulta matters** — the Supreme Court has voided projects, permits, and even laws granted or passed without the genuine prior consultation the affected communities were owed. **But assemblies can be manipulated**, the government shields megaprojects as "national security," the amparo is slow, and defenders face lethal danger. The through-line: **guard the assembly; take any rigged approval to the agrarian court; file an amparo for a suspensión; demand consulta; challenge the MIA and the water concession; mobilise the public — and expect a long fight measured in delay, conditions, and exposure as much as an outright stop.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point. Vague opposition to "the dam" goes nowhere; opposition to "the environmental authorisation and water concession granted on a rigged assembly the agrarian court can annul, without the consulta previa ILO 169 requires" is a case. Answer five questions.

The Five Core Questions

1. What exactly is proposed, and on whose land? Name the project, the proponent, and — first of all — **whose land** it sits on. Is it **ejido or comunidad (social property)**, which brings the assembly and the agrarian courts into play? Then the specific permits: the environmental authorisation (MIA), the water concession, any concession or contract. Each is a place a defect hides.

2. What stage is it at? Trying to secure the land through an assembly? MIA under review at SEMARNAT? Authorisation granted? Water concession issued? In the courts? Under construction? The stage dictates the door. If the assembly is being sought, guarding it is the powerful route now; if permits are granted, the amparo and the agrarian court are the route.

3. Is it on collective land — and is the assembly sound? This is often the decisive Mexican question. On ejido or comunidad land, was there a **valid assembly** — properly convened, with quorum, freely deciding — or a rigged one you can annul in the agrarian court? Guarding or challenging the assembly is frequently the strongest single move.

4. Are Indigenous peoples affected, and was there consulta? Where Indigenous or equivalent communities are affected, a **consulta previa** under ILO 169 is required, and its absence is among the strongest grounds — the Supreme Court has voided projects for it. Establish whether it happened and whether it was genuine.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching? Which authorities issued the land use, the MIA, and the water; who owns, funds, and profits from the proponent (including the State); which communities, ejidos, and organisations are engaged; and which agrarian and human-rights lawyers, environmental groups, press, and international allies can be reached. This maps your levers and your audiences at once.

A Worked Example

Suppose the CFE, or a company, proposes a dam or mine on ejido and comunidad land, seeking the assemblies' consent, with the MIA under review.

Working the five questions: the project sits on **collective land**, so the **assembly** is the gate — guard it, and watch for any attempt to rig it. It is **seeking land consent and environmental authorisation**, so guarding the assembly and challenging the MIA are the live routes now, with the agrarian court and an amparo in reserve. If the communities are **Indigenous or equivalent**, **consulta previa** is required. The permits and the water concession may be defective. The

assembly and the courts carry more weight than quiet lobbying.

Within a weekend you have moved from "we oppose the dam" to a target list: organise to guard the assembly and document any manipulation; prepare to annul a rigged assembly in the agrarian court; file a denuncia with PROFEPA and scrutinise the MIA; establish the consulta right; line up agrarian and amparo lawyers for a suspensión; challenge the water concession; and prepare the land-and-river story for the press. That is a campaign, not a complaint. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete, assignable tasks — guard the assembly, file the denuncia, ready the amparo, establish the consulta right — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin this week, several of them before the assembly is even convened or the authorisation granted. That is the difference the five questions make.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. An agrarian-court judge, a federal amparo judge, a journalist, and a proponent's financiers all move on evidence, not indignation. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **assembly records (actas de asamblea)** — the convocation, the attendance, the quorum, the vote — which are where a rigged approval is exposed; the **MIA and the environmental authorisation** from SEMARNAT; the **water concession** from CONAGUA; any **consulta record**; and the ejido or comunidad's own agrarian documents. Much is obtainable through Mexico's **transparency law** and the access-to-information system. The gap between what the paper claims — a valid assembly, an adequate impact statement, a genuine consulta — and what actually happened is where cases are won. CECOP's victory rested exactly here: proving that the assemblies the CFE relied on were invalid. Read the assembly records with special care — the date and form of the convocation, the list of who was entitled to vote and who actually attended, whether the quorum the law demands was truly met, whether the vote was free — because this is where manufactured consent falls apart. And read the MIA against the grain, for the effect scoped out in a sentence, the displacement undercounted, the water demand softened; it is written by consultants paid to secure the authorisation, and its gaps are your grounds.

Layer 2: The Ground Truth

Document the reality the paper hides. Photograph and date the **actual land** — the river, the fields, the forest, the community, the footprint — and geotag it. Log **incidents**: a coerced meeting, an intimidation, works beyond permit, a diverted stream. Capture **before-and-after** with your own photos and with freely available satellite imagery, to show clearing or the true scale. Record **who lives and farms here** — the ejidatarios and comuneros, the land use, the water sources — because collective landholding and use are the heart of the agrarian case. Record **testimony**: above all, first-hand accounts of how an assembly was convened and conducted, since procedural fraud is the classic ground for annulment; and residents', farmers', and independent experts' accounts of the harm.

Layer 3: The Defects and the Rights

Finally, document the failures of process and the legal lines the project crosses. Was the **assembly invalid** — no proper convocation, no quorum, coerced, or fabricated? Was **consulta previa** skipped or staged? Was the **MIA deficient** — understating the flooding, the displacement, the water, the species, the cumulative effects? Was the **water concession** unlawful? Does the project violate the constitutional rights to a **healthy environment** or to **water**? Each defect is a separate ground — for an agrarian-court annulment, an amparo, a consulta claim, a PROFEPA denuncia — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Mexican fights, because here a project that looked authorised is revealed to rest on a rigged assembly, a skipped consulta, a deficient impact statement, or an unlawful water grab. Work it methodically against each requirement: was the assembly validly convened and carried; was consulta previa owed and genuinely held; did the MIA honestly assess the flooding, displacement, water, and species; was the water concession lawfully granted; does the project respect the rights to a healthy environment and to water? Where the answer is no, capture the proof — because each 'no' is a separate ground the agrarian court, an amparo, PROFEPA, or the Supreme Court can act on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Mexican cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose your project's particular defect.

The Land, the Permits, and Their Paper Trail

- **The assembly records (actas de asamblea)** — the convocation, attendance list, quorum, and vote — from the ejido or comunidad and the agrarian registry (RAN). These are decisive: a defective convocation or quorum is the classic ground to annul.
- **The MIA and the environmental authorisation**, from SEMARNAT. Read the MIA for what it understates — the flooding, the displacement, the water, the species, the cumulative effects.
- **The water concession**, from CONAGUA — whether it was lawfully granted for this use.
- **Any consulta record** — whether a consulta previa happened, how, and whether the community accepts it as genuine.
- **The ejido/comunidad documents** — the census of ejidatarios/comuneros, the internal rules, the land plan (from the RAN).
- **Contracts, concessions, and permits** tying the proponent to the land and the project.

How to Get Them

Assembly records are held by the ejido and the **Registro Agrario Nacional**; environmental documents by SEMARNAT; water by CONAGUA. For everything else, use Mexico's **transparency law and access-to-information system (the national platform)**: a request to the authority obliges a response, with the transparency institute behind you if it is refused. A refusal is itself a documentable fact. Move early: guarding an assembly must happen before the vote, and the deadlines for an **amparo** (which run from when you learn of the act) and for agrarian challenges are strict, so evidence and objections gathered while the doors are open carry far more weight — and preserve far more of your rights — than the same point raised later. A practical tip: request the assembly records from the Registro Agrario Nacional as well as from the comisariado, so you can compare the official file with what the community witnessed — discrepancies between the two are often the clearest proof of a rigged assembly. Keep dated proof of every request and every refusal, and treat a refusal as both a documentable fact and a signal of where the weakness lies.

The Ground Evidence

- **Dated, geotagged photographs and video** of the land, the river, the community, the works.
- **Satellite before-and-after** from freely available imagery, to show clearing, flooding, or the true extent.
- **First-hand accounts of the assembly** — who was convened, who attended, how the vote was taken — since procedural fraud is the classic ground for annulment; record them carefully and, where possible, in writing or on video.
- **Independent technical readings** — a hydrologist's, ecologist's, or agronomist's report, and an independent review of the MIA. Environmental and agrarian organisations and university clinics can help source these.
- **Maps** overlaying the footprint on the ejido and comunidad land, the river, the water sources, and any protected area — a single map showing a reservoir over collective land and a community's water is worth pages of argument.
- **Testimony** from ejidatarios, comuneros, and residents on the land, the water, and the harm.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of every assembly, permit, concession, consulta, and deadline, plus incidents — the spine of any agrarian case or amparo. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a volunteer, a lawyer, a journalist, and a judge all see the same clear picture fast — and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the other side challenges it. In a fight that can run for years — La Parota ran for twenty-three — and pass through many hands, the community with the better-kept file is very often the one that prevails.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO ORGANISE A MOVEMENT THAT LASTS

Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised people do — sustained, visible, and credible over the months or years a fight takes. This is the step CECOP did best: campesinos who organised, guarded their assemblies, and held together for more than two decades.

Phase 1: The Core, and the Assembly

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work. On collective land, the single most important early task is to **organise around the assembly**: understand who the recognised ejidatarios and comuneros are, ensure they attend, and be ready to document and challenge any attempt to convene a rigged or coerced meeting. The assembly is your gate; guarding it is job one. Assign roles: documentation, legal liaison (agrarian and amparo), assembly organising, media, community liaison, and coordination. Agree on the goal — a project blocked at the assembly, a rigged assembly annulled, a permit frozen by amparo, a cancellation — and on what you will and will not accept.

Phase 2: The Coalition

Then widen deliberately. Bring in **neighbouring ejidos and comunidades, campesino and Indigenous organisations, fishers, students, scientists, and faith networks**. Reach the **allies with capacity** — the agrarian-rights and human-rights organisations and lawyers who litigate these cases; the national and international networks (as International Rivers and others were for CECOP) whose reach and expertise amplify a local fight; independent experts; and the reputational-pressure campaigners who reach financiers and buyers. CECOP drew its power from exactly this breadth — dozens of communities united across a region, joined to national and international allies — which is precisely the spread a winning campaign needs.

A worked coalition example. Facing a dam on collective land, several ejidos and comunidades unite in a council; they guard their assemblies together; they bring in agrarian and amparo lawyers and an independent hydrologist; a national organisation amplifies the fight; and international allies raise its profile. No single community could have carried it; together they cover the assemblies, the courts, the science, the legitimacy, and the national and international reach — the CECOP model.

Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — an assembly held firm, a rigged assembly annulled, a suspensión granted, a document pried loose. Rotate the exhausting roles. And protect people — this is grave in Mexico, one of the deadliest countries for defenders, and CECOP's own leaders faced imprisonment and persecution: keep leadership collective and visible; document every threat; build strong links to human-rights organisations, the CNDH, the press, and international networks that raise the cost of harming a known leader; and get security and legal advice. Sustaining a campaign — as CECOP's twenty-three years show — is how these fights are won, and the ones that endure pace themselves. Build in the things that keep people together and safe: welcome newcomers, share food, mark the victories, root the campaign in the community's own life and its assembly, and never let a leader stand alone and exposed. A fight that can run for decades survives only if it becomes part of who the community is — and in Mexico, collective and visible leadership is not only how a movement endures but part of how its people are kept alive.

Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen. Turn people out for the assemblies, the hearings, and public meetings. Hold peaceful, well-documented actions — the roadblocks and gatherings that made La Parota a national story from the first blockade of CFE engineers in 2003. Be clear-eyed about safety and legal risk, and take advice, especially where actions or the defence of land could expose leaders to criminalisation. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate, to the authorities, the courts, the proponent, and the public, that the opposition is broad, rooted, and not going away — and that the assembly will not be delivered. Choose actions that photograph well and that anyone can join — a march to the state capital, a gathering on the threatened land, an assembly held in the open and well documented — and record them yourselves, so the breadth and spirit of the resistance survive as a record even if no outlet covers them. A visibly broad, peaceful, rooted movement, standing on its own collective land, is among the most persuasive arguments an authority or a court can weigh.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE ASSEMBLY, THE AGRARIAN COURT, THE AMPARO, AND CONSULTA

Mexican law gives communities a real arsenal, and you do not need a final ruling to win with it: guarding an assembly, annulling a rigged one, or winning an amparo suspension delays a project, forces disclosure, and creates leverage and headlines. Engage agrarian and amparo lawyers early — but understand the tools yourself.

The Assembly and the Agrarian Court

On ejido and comunidad land, the first and often strongest lever is the **assembly**. Under the Agrarian Law, the use or transfer of collective land requires a **valid asamblea** — properly convened, with the required quorum, freely deciding. Guard it: no valid assembly, no valid project. This is worth dwelling on, because it inverts the usual balance of power: on collective land the community is not a mere objector hoping to influence a distant decision-maker — it is the owner whose consent the project actually requires, and whose assembly is a decision the law puts in the community's own hands. Losing that consent, or having it faked, is the single most damaging thing that can happen to a campaign; keeping it whole is the single most powerful. And where a proponent manufactures consent through a rigged or coerced assembly — as the CFE did at La Parota — you can take it to the **Tribunal Unitario Agrario** and have it **annulled**, which pulls the legal ground out from under the project. This is the distinctly Mexican move that stopped La Parota, and it is available wherever collective land is at stake. The system rests on Article 27 of the Constitution and the Agrarian Law: an ejido or comunidad governs its land through the assembly of its recognised members, with an elected comisariado to represent it, and the most important decisions — above all the use or transfer of common land — require a specially convened assembly with a heightened quorum and formalities recorded at the Registro Agrario Nacional. Those formalities are not red tape; they are the community's protection, and a proponent that cuts corners on them hands you the ground to void the whole approval.

The Amparo and the Suspensión

Mexico's great constitutional tool is the **amparo** — a suit in the federal courts that an act of authority violates constitutional rights. Its power for communities is the **suspensión**: an order that **freezes** the challenged act — an environmental authorisation, a water concession, the works themselves — while the case is decided. An amparo can be grounded in the rights to a **healthy environment** and to **water** (Article 4), the right to **consulta** (Article 2), or a defective permit, and it reaches up to the **Suprema Corte**. It can be slow, and suspensions can be contested, but a suspensión won early can halt a project for years — and even a temporary halt shifts the ground, buying the time in which assemblies are defended, evidence is gathered, allies are found, and a proponent's patience and finance are tested — as the 2007 amparo did at La Parota against the illegal environmental clearance and water concession. The suspension comes in two stages — a provisional suspension that can freeze the act almost immediately while the court considers it, and a definitive suspension that holds for the life of the case — which is why filing early matters so much: a provisional suspension won in the first days can stop bulldozers before they start. The amparo is technical and the deadlines strict (generally counted from when you learn of the act), so competent counsel is worth finding, even though the Constitution does not, in principle, require a lawyer to file one.

Consulta Previa

Where Indigenous or equivalent communities are affected, **consulta previa** under **ILO Convention 169** and the Constitution is among the strongest grounds. The consultation must be **prior, free, informed, culturally appropriate, and aimed at agreement** — not a meeting held after the decision is made. The **Suprema Corte** has repeatedly **voided projects, permits, and even laws** granted or passed without a proper consulta, in cases from wind farms to aqueducts to genetically modified crops. Where your community is entitled to consulta and did not genuinely receive it, that defect can undo the project — a lever led by the affected community, whose leadership you support rather than supplant. In practice that means offering capacity — research, evidence, logistics, a legal contact — rather than direction, and accepting that the community may pursue the fight on its own terms and at its own pace; the consulta right and the land are theirs, and a campaign that forgets it both wrongs the people it claims to serve and weakens the strongest ground the case stands on. Mexico ratified ILO Convention 169 in 1990, and Article 2 of the Constitution recognises Indigenous and Afro-Mexican peoples' rights, including to consultation; the Supreme Court has built a substantial body of rulings insisting the consulta be genuine, and has struck down wind projects, an aqueduct, and even a permit for genetically modified crops where it was absent or a sham. The consultation must reach the community through its own representative institutions and in its own language, with enough information and time to decide — a briefing staged to tick a box is not a consulta, and the courts have said so plainly.

The Environmental Route and the Water Concession

Two further levers complete the arsenal. The **environmental authorisation** rests on the **MIA**, and a deficient impact statement — understating the flooding, displacement, water, or species — can be challenged, while any citizen can file a **denuncia popular** with **PROFEPA**, which can inspect, sanction, and suspend. And the **water concession** from CONAGUA can be questioned where it was unlawfully granted — water was central to the La Parota challenge, and is central to many Mexican fights. and because water scarcity touches everyone in a community whether or not they hold land, Water is often the sharpest edge of a Mexican project, because a dam, mine, brewery, or resort typically needs a large concession from CONAGUA, and those concessions — in a country of deep water stress — are both legally

contestable and politically explosive; a community that can show a project would take water it cannot spare has an argument that reaches the courts, the regulator, and the public at once. Pair the water case with the MIA challenge and the PROFEPA denuncia, and you have three environmental fronts running together.

Where to File and With Whom

Assembly disputes run in the **Tribunales Agrarios**; amparos in the federal courts up to the **SCJN**; consulta claims through the amparo and the courts; environmental complaints to **PROFEPA**. Get help early: agrarian-rights and human-rights organisations, environmental and amparo lawyers, and legal clinics know exactly these procedures and can advise on the strongest ground, the strict deadlines, the suspensión, and how a non-Indigenous community can properly support a consulta case. A lawyer engaged before the assembly, and while the amparo deadline is alive, is worth far more than help sought after the machinery arrives. Ask at the first meeting which lever is strongest for your facts — an assembly guarded or annulled is often more decisive than any permit challenge, because it denies the project its land entirely — and clarify the strict, unforgiving deadlines for the amparo and the agrarian action, because a good case lost to a missed deadline is the most avoidable defeat there is.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades an agrarian judge, a federal amparo judge, an environmental official, a journalist, a financier, and the community itself in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a dam was authorised on the strength of a rigged assembly, on a MIA that understated the flooding, without the consulta previa the communities were owed. That one fact becomes:

- **An agrarian argument:** the assembly was invalid — improperly convened, without quorum, coerced — and must be annulled in the Tribunal Agrario, voiding the land consent.
- **A consulta argument:** the communities' right to free, prior, and informed consultation was denied — a ground the Supreme Court has used to void projects.
- **An amparo argument:** the environmental authorisation and water concession violate the rights to a healthy environment and to water — grounds for a suspensión freezing the project.
- **A media argument:** a mega-dam pushed through on a fixed assembly and a whitewashed impact statement, over a community that was never truly consulted — a clear, human story.
- **A reputational argument:** a project resting on an annulable assembly and a challengeable permit is a legal and reputational risk to its financiers and contractors.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Mexico the arguments that most often decide things are the **invalid assembly and the missing consulta**, because they pull the legal ground out from under the project, and the **amparo**, because its suspensión can freeze the works while the rest plays out. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the court file and a claim made to the court can be spoken plainly at an assembly; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive. Learning to move fluently between these registers — the invalid assembly for the agrarian court, the missing consulta for the Supreme Court, the water and environment for the community and the public, the reputational risk for the financier, the human story for the reporter — is one of the most valuable skills a campaign develops, because it lets the same underlying evidence work every lever at once without ever straying from the facts.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The agrarian and federal courts want the illegality framed precisely against the specific rule — the Agrarian Law on assemblies, ILO 169 on consulta, Article 4 on environment and water, the defective MIA — with the documents and the timeline that prove it.

Environmental officials and PROFEPA respond to legal risk and their mandate — the deficient MIA, the harm, the reasons to inspect and sanction.

Journalists need a specific, verified, human story with a hook: a named river, a named community, a rigged assembly, a documented defect, a live decision.

Financiers, contractors, and buyers respond to legal and reputational exposure — a contested project on an annulable assembly and a challengeable permit, tied to a named proponent.

The community itself needs to see that the fight is winnable and shared — the small wins, the growing movement, the pressure mounting — so it lasts through the years these fights take.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the political cost of a project, reaches officials, ministers, and the proponent's backers your letters cannot, protects activists by making them visible — which matters intensely in Mexico — and can turn a local fight into a national and international cause. CECOP proved it: for over two decades, the images of campesinos defending the Papagayo, and the story of a community that would not sell its land, kept La Parota a national issue until it was cancelled.

Build the Story

Reporters need specifics: a named place and people, a dated and documented defect or harm, a clear stake, and a live decision or deadline. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a mega-dam was pushed through on a fixed assembly and would flood 17,000 hectares and displace 25,000 people, and the community is fighting it in the agrarian courts" is. Lead with your strongest verified fact, attach the map and the imagery, and offer a human voice — a comunero, a community leader, a scientist — and a striking image, as the Papagayo and its defenders became. Mexican and international audiences respond powerfully to land and water and to the defence of the commons: a named river, a community that refuses to sell its land, a rigged assembly exposed, and a decision with a date carry a moral clarity that a debate about megawatts never will. CECOP's slogan — that the land is not for sale — told the whole story in a single line, and it is that concrete, rooted stake that reporters and the public remember.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and regional media** first, where the project is felt. Then **national outlets** — the major papers and Mexico's strong investigative and independent press — which carry political weight. Then, for a project touching a listed company, an international financier, or a globally resonant value (Indigenous rights, a great river, biodiversity), **international and financial media**, which reach the money and the world. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. Pay particular attention to the rings that reach the **money and the government**: national coverage raises the political cost, and international and reputational coverage can reach a proponent's financiers where the domestic process cannot. It is worth identifying the specific environment, agrarian, and human-rights reporters at the national papers and the strong independent outlets, and the international correspondents who cover Indigenous rights and megaprojects; a journalist who already knows the terrain needs less briefing and carries more weight, and a single well-sourced investigation into a rigged assembly or a whitewashed impact statement can move a minister or a financier more than a month of press releases. Offer your strongest documented finding as an exclusive and you gain an ally, not just a mention.

Sustain It, Make It Safe and True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the assembly, the court ruling, the amparo, the new document, the action — so there is always a next hook, and build your own record (a simple site, a social feed, a growing album of dated photographs and video) so the story exists in a form journalists can pick up and that survives if posts are removed. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent; one exaggeration handed to the other side can cost you credibility you cannot rebuild. And weigh safety in every choice — in Mexico, visibility can protect a leader, but exposure can also endanger one, so coordinate with human-rights organisations on how and when to raise a profile. Verified, specific, human, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and

grounded in the law and the evidence.

8A. Objection / Denuncia to PROFEPA and SEMARNAT

To: PROFEPA (denuncia popular) and SEMARNAT **Subject:** Denuncia popular — [project], [location]

As a person/community affected by [project] at [location], I file this denuncia. My grounds, with evidence: (1) the MIA [understates/omits] [impact — e.g. the flooding, the displacement, the water, the species]; (2) [the environmental authorisation was granted despite [defect]]; (3) [works are proceeding beyond or without authorisation]; (4) [the project harms the right to a healthy environment and to water]. I request that PROFEPA inspect, investigate, and — where warranted — order the suspension of the activity, and that SEMARNAT reconsider the authorisation. [Attachments: photographs, technical note, maps.]

8B. Transparency / Access-to-Information Request

To: [SEMARNAT / CONAGUA / the Registro Agrario Nacional / the authority] **Subject:** Solicitud de acceso a la información — [project]

Under the transparency and access-to-information law, I request: the MIA and the environmental authorisation; the water concession; the assembly records (actas de asamblea) held in the agrarian registry; any consulta record; and [correspondence between the proponent and the authority on [issue]]. Please respond within the legal period. I note the public interest in environmental and land information.

8C. Instructing Agrarian / Amparo Counsel

To: an agrarian-rights or human-rights lawyer or organisation **Subject:** [Project] — assembly annulment and/or amparo

We believe the [project] on our ejido/comunidad land is unlawful because [the assembly relied on was invalid — improperly convened / without quorum / coerced; the environmental authorisation and water concession are defective; consulta previa was skipped]. We attach the assembly records, the MIA, the concession, and our timeline, and seek your advice on **annulling the assembly in the Tribunal Agrario** and/or an **amparo with a suspensión**, the strict deadlines, and the strongest ground. Time is critical.

8D. Supporting a Community's Consulta / Rights (at their invitation)

To: [the authority / the court], with the community's agreement **Subject:** [Project] — consulta previa and the rights of [community]

As a community group in [place], at the invitation of and in support of [Indigenous/equivalent community], we underline the rights it has asserted regarding [project]: its right to **free, prior, and informed consultation** under ILO Convention 169 and the Constitution, and its rights to its land, water, and environment. We do not speak for the community; we stand with it, and we ask that its right to consulta be honoured before any authorisation or works proceed. [Attach material the community is content to have shared.]

8E. Letter to a Financier / Contractor / Buyer

To: [the project's financier / contractor / buyer] **Subject:** [Project] — legal and reputational risk

We write regarding your [financing of / work on / purchasing from] [proponent] in connection with [project]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "rests on an assembly the agrarian court can annul and a permit under amparo challenge, and is opposed by the affected communities"], and our documented concerns include [the invalid assembly, the missing consulta, the deficient MIA, the pending suspensión]. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and financial risk, and whether your own [environmental, social, and human-rights commitments] are consistent with supporting it. We are glad to share our evidence.

8F. Letter to an Official / Legislator / the CNDH

To: [the relevant authority / a legislator / the Comisión Nacional de los Derechos Humanos] **Subject:** [Project] — concerns and request

We are residents of [place] writing about [project]. Our concern, briefly: [one or two specific grounds — a rigged assembly, a threat to a community's land and water, a skipped consulta, threats against defenders]. Within your responsibility, we

ask you to [halt or review the authorisation / uphold the assembly and consulta rights / protect the defenders at risk]. [If true:] [#] communities and organisations share this concern, and the project carries real legal risk. We welcome a meeting and can share our full evidence.

8G. Email to a Reporter (Regional, National, or International)

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the community]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear news hook: [documents] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a mega-dam was pushed through on a fixed assembly, would flood 17,000 hectares and displace thousands, and is being fought in the agrarian courts"], with [a decision/hearing] due [date]. It is specific, verified, and it echoes La Parota. I can share the full file and — where the community wishes to speak — connect you with affected people and an expert. Could we talk this week?

8H. Letter Requesting Protective Measures for Defenders

To: [the CNDH / the federal protection mechanism for defenders], copied to allies **Subject:** Protection request — defenders of [community] opposing [project]

We report that leaders and members of [community/organisation] opposing [project] face [threats / intimidation / criminalisation / violence]: [sourced facts, dates]. Given Mexico's documented dangers for land and environmental defenders, we request [protective measures / an investigation / monitoring], and we are informing human-rights organisations and the press. We attach the record of incidents.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — above all the assembly dates and the strict amparo and agrarian deadlines. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the law and the evidence; attach your documentation; and route them, where you can, through or with the affected community (following its lead), your agrarian and amparo lawyers, and your human-rights and international allies. The reply — or the silence — becomes part of your record, and in Mexico that record feeds the levers that matter most: the assembly and the agrarian court, the amparo, consulta, the environmental route, and the public — with the protection of your people woven through all of it.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

1. Guard the assembly — first, if it's collective land. On ejido or comunidad land, the assembly is the gate. Organise so recognised ejidatarios and comuneros attend, and document any attempt to convene a rigged or coerced meeting. No valid assembly, no valid project — the single highest-leverage move there is. Elsewhere a community can only ask a distant official to say no; on ejido or comunidad land, the community itself holds the yes-or-no, and that is a power worth defending with everything you have.

2. Check for Indigenous status and consulta. Establish whether the affected communities are entitled to **consulta previa** and whether it genuinely happened. A missing consulta is a ground the Supreme Court has used to void projects.

3. File an amparo for a suspensión — mind the deadline. The moment an unlawful permit, concession, or work appears, an amparo (8C) can freeze it. The deadline runs from when you learn of the act, so move fast and get legal advice.

4. Get the documents. The assembly records, MIA, and water concession are obtainable through the transparency system (8B). The gap between the paper and the reality is usually the case.

5. File a denuncia with PROFEPA. A denuncia popular (8A) can trigger an inspection and even a suspension, and it costs nothing.

6. Take a rigged assembly to the agrarian court. If consent was manufactured, the Tribunal Agrario can annul it (8C) — the move that stopped La Parota.

7. Tell the story and protect your people. A river, a community's land, a rigged assembly is a powerful story (8G); and in Mexico, build protection for exposed leaders in from the start (8H).

Do only the first three and you will have guarded the gate, identified your strongest ground, and — if needed — frozen the project while you regroup. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: guard the assembly, check consulta, file the amparo. Everything else in this guide amplifies those three moves. A community that does only them has already done more than most projects' opponents ever manage — and, on collective land, has often done enough to deny the project lawful ground, put the consulta question on the table, and freeze the works while a fuller fight is built.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Mexico's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that still work.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt shows first in the **assembly itself**: a determined proponent can try to **manipulate, buy, or split** the community, convening rigged meetings and manufacturing consent, exactly as the CFE did at La Parota — so the gate must be guarded, not assumed. Beyond that, the federal government pushes large infrastructure hard and has **declared major projects matters of "national security,"** an attempt to **shield them from injunctions and transparency** — a tactic deployed around the **Tren Maya** and other megaprojects, which the courts have only partly curbed. In 2021 the government issued an agreement declaring its flagship infrastructure — including the Tren Maya railway across the Yucatán and the Interoceanic Corridor — to be in the public and national interest and matters of national security, which was used to withhold information and to resist the amparos and suspensions that communities and environmental groups had obtained. The Supreme Court later struck down key parts of that attempt to place projects beyond judicial and public scrutiny, but the episode is a candid warning: for a project the State treats as strategic, expect it to reach for tools that narrow the community's normal levers, and plan to contest that framing itself. The **amparo**, though powerful, can be **slow**, and its suspensions contested. And Mexico is **one of the deadliest countries in the world for land and environmental defenders**, with criminalisation, threats, and violence a real and recurring danger — CECOP's own leaders were imprisoned and persecuted. International monitors have for years placed Mexico among the countries with the most killings of land and environmental defenders, and the tools used against them include not only violence but the courts themselves — fabricated criminal charges intended to tie up and intimidate a movement's leaders. This is not a reason to abandon the fight, but it is a reason to build protection into every decision from the first day: collective and rotating leadership, documented threats, fast links to human-rights organisations and the CNDH, and, where warranted, formal protective measures. Where this tilt bites, the formal process gives less than it should — but real levers still reach past it.

What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers reach past it.

Collective land cannot simply be taken. The assembly requirement is structural: guard it, and the project has no lawful land; rig it, and the agrarian court can annul the fraud — a barrier that does not depend on the government's goodwill.

Consulta is enforced by the Supreme Court. The right to prior consultation has voided projects, permits, and even laws, whatever the executive wanted.

The amparo reaches the highest court. However a project is framed — even as "national security" — an amparo can test it against constitutional rights, and the courts have pushed back on attempts to place projects beyond judicial reach.

The record and the movement endure. What you document powers agrarian cases and amparos over years, and an organised community — the CECOP model — outlasts a proponent betting on fatigue.

Mobilisation and international attention endure. The tradition of campesino and community resistance, joined to national and international allies, is a force no permit can dissolve.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Mexico is real but demanding. Collective land and the assembly, the agrarian courts, the amparo,

consulta, and a deep resistance tradition give a community genuine — in places distinctive — power, as La Parota proved. But assemblies can be manipulated, the government shields its megaprojects as "national security," the amparo is slow, and defenders face lethal danger. So diagnose the tilt honestly: guard the assembly above all, lean on the agrarian courts, the amparo, consulta, and the mobilisation, not on official goodwill; document every defect; protect your people first and always; treat a win as something to be defended, not banked — La Parota's 2012 accords held only because the community stayed organised for the fourteen more years it took to reach definitive cancellation; and think in terms of delay, conditions, exposure, and a proponent worn down as much as an outright, permanent stop. Against a State-backed megaproject, that is often what winning looks like — and it is real.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sometimes a project advances not despite the evidence but because someone is being improperly favoured, pressured, or paid. Undue influence changes your strategy: you stop trying to persuade a captured decision-maker and start exposing and going around them.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **rigged assembly** — convened without proper notice, without quorum, with outsiders or coerced voters — is itself often the fingerprint of corruption. An **environmental authorisation granted against the evidence**, over a plainly deficient MIA; a **consulta staged** as a formality; **payments, jobs, or contracts** steered to a local power broker or a compliant assembly leader; a **water concession** granted irregularly; **conditions never enforced**; and a project **wrapped in "national security"** to escape scrutiny all point the same way. And **threats, criminalisation, or violence against the community's leaders** — tragically common in Mexico — are themselves a signature of something deeply wrong. One anomaly may be error; a pattern is capture.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where undue influence reaches. A **local assembly leader (comisariado), a municipal official, a state authority, or a single agency** can be pressured, bought, or captured. But the Mexican system has bodies harder to reach that a captured local arrangement cannot easily control: the **Tribunales Agrarios** and the federal courts up to the **SCJN**; **PROFEPA** and the environmental authorities at the federal level; the **CNDH**; the **Auditoría Superior de la Federación**; the international human-rights system and the Escazú framework; and a vigorous national and international press. Undue influence thrives on darkness and on staying local; your task is to lift the matter out of the captured node and into the light and the higher, cleaner fora.

What to Do

Do not confront and tip off the captured decision-maker. Instead, **document the anomaly precisely** — the defective assembly, the steered payments, the staged consulta, the irregular concession — and take it, with evidence, to the bodies above: the Tribunal Agrario, the federal courts through an amparo, PROFEPA, the CNDH, the auditor, and the press. Pair the referral with the assembly annulment, the amparo, and the reputational pressure, so the wrongdoing and the harm are exposed together. Exposure has its own momentum: an agrarian-court annulment or a court's attention creates a record other bodies must reckon with, and a rigged assembly proven is the collapse of the project's legal foundation. And protect yourself above all — this is life-and-death in parts of Mexico: get security and legal advice, coordinate with human-rights organisations and the CNDH, keep the work collective and visible, and never carry it alone.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight.

Early (Weeks 0-8): Identify, Organise the Assembly, and Document

Pin down the project, the land, and the stage (Step 1), and — on collective land — **organise around the assembly** at once (Step 3). Begin the file — get the assembly records, MIA, and water concession through the transparency system (Step 2 and What to Gather). And move fast on what will not wait: **guard the assembly, file a denuncia with PROFEPA, establish the consulta right**, and, if an unlawful act has occurred, **file an amparo for a suspensión** within

its deadline. Reach agrarian and amparo lawyers and human-rights organisations, and put protection for exposed leaders in place. This early phase is cheap, and it sets up everything else.

Middle (Months 2-36): Escalate on Every Front

Grow the movement and coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — annul a rigged assembly in the **Tribunal Agrario**, press the **amparo** and its **suspensión**, bring the **consulta** claim, and challenge the **MIA** and the **water concession** (Step 4). Refer any capture to the courts, PROFEPA, the CNDH, and the auditor. Press the financiers and contractors (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the cheap, time-sensitive things first, because a lost assembly or a lapsed amparo deadline cannot be recovered. And sequence the moves with your lawyers and the community so they land when they bite hardest — the assembly guarded before the vote, the provisional suspension sought the moment an unlawful act appears, the consulta claim led by the affected community, the agrarian annulment pressed on the fullest proof of fraud — because in the Mexican system a single well-timed move can matter more than a stronger argument made too late.

Later (Months 6 to years): Sustain, Win the Line, and Redefine the Win

Sustain the movement against burnout; protect your people; keep the record and the coverage alive. Pursue the durable prizes — a **project blocked at the assembly**, a **rigged assembly annulled**, a **permit or work frozen by amparo**, a **project voided for want of consulta**, a **cancellation**. And judge success honestly. Sometimes it is an outright stop — a dam cancelled, a river saved, as La Parota finally was. More often, against a determined State, it is a project **delayed for years, shrunk, conditioned, or so exposed and legally besieged that it is abandoned**. That is not a lesser victory. It is what winning usually looks like — and remember that La Parota's decisive halt in 2012 became a definitive cancellation only in 2026, because the community never stopped.

The Shape of a Campaign

WEEKS 0-8	Identify Organise the assembly Document Denuncia to PROFEPA Amparo if needed Protect leaders
MONTHS 2-36	Grow the movement Arguments Agrarian court + amparo + consulta + MIA/water Financiers Media
MONTHS/YEARS	Sustain Protect people Win the annulment / suspensión / cancellation Defend the win Redefine it

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Mexico gives communities a genuinely powerful — and, in places, distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. On the roughly half of Mexico that is **social property**, a project needs the **assembly's** consent — a gate the community controls, and, if it is rigged, one the **agrarian courts** will void, as they did at La Parota. Over everything sits the **amparo**, whose **suspensión** can freeze an unlawful permit, concession, or work while the case is fought, up to the **Suprema Corte**. Where Indigenous or equivalent communities are affected, **consulta previa** — enforced by that Court, which has voided projects, permits, and laws — is among the strongest grounds anywhere. And the environmental route (the **MIA** challenge, the **PROFEPA** denuncia) and a **deep resistance tradition** complete the arsenal.

The limits are just as real. Assemblies can be manipulated; the government shields its megaprojects as "national security"; the amparo is slow; and Mexico is one of the most dangerous places on Earth to defend land and rivers. No guide should pretend otherwise. La Parota took twenty-three years, and its 2012 halt held only because the community stayed organised until the definitive cancellation in 2026; that endurance is the condition of this fight, not its exception.

So the realistic promise is this: **guard the assembly above all, take any rigged approval to the agrarian court, file an amparo for a suspensión, demand and enforce consulta, challenge the MIA and the water, mobilise the public, and protect your people first — and run all of it together, following the affected community's lead**. Do that, and even against a State-backed megaproject you can force delay, conditions, exposure, an annulled assembly, a frozen permit, a voided authorisation, and a proponent worn down — and, in the end, an outright stop. Do it as CECOP did, owning its land in common, guarding its assemblies, and holding for twenty-three years, and you can win a victory that protects not only your own river but sets a precedent others will stand on.

A last word on endurance. These fights are won in years — sometimes decades — not weeks, and the proponent is counting on your exhaustion, and, in Mexico, sometimes on your fear. Its advantage is money, patience, and power; yours

is legitimacy, the land you hold in common and govern through your own assembly, the amparo, the right to be consulted, and the plain fact that you are defending your home and your river while it is merely pursuing a return. Play to that. Keep the file, keep the assembly, keep the movement, keep the record and the coverage alive, protect your people, and treat every delay, every annulled assembly, every suspensión, every disclosed document, and every headline as a brick in a wall that grows too high and too costly for the project to climb.

The tools are here, and La Parota proves they work: a mega-dam that would have drowned a valley and displaced twenty-five thousand people was stopped and, at last, cancelled, because a community owned its land in common, refused to let its assembly be stolen, and held the line for twenty-three years. What decides the outcome is method, endurance, and courage — and those you supply. Begin today, begin cheaply, and build from there. Communities before you have stopped what looked unstoppable — a mega-dam cancelled after twenty-three years, an assembly defended against every attempt to steal it, a river left to run free. The tools are here, and the strongest of them — the land held in common and the amparo — rest in the community's own hands; what has ever been missing in the fights that were lost was not the law but the organisation, the endurance, and the protection to use it. So can yours.